Manuscript families in Revelation

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The *Text und Textwert* edition of the Apocalypse recognizes three main lines of transmission, manuscript families, in Revelation. It calls them 'Koine', 'Andreas' and 'Complutensian', which basically agrees with my understanding of Hoskier. Of Hoskier's nine families, the Hodges-Farstad Majority Text used only the four largest ones, plus a smaller one, that they called **M^{a,b,c,d,e}**. The 'Koine' is made up of **a** and **b**, plus two small groups that I call **f** and **g**. The 'Andreas' is made up of **d** and **e** (the **h** that I included in 'Andreas', they divided into three small groups with shifting affinities). The 'Complutensian' is made up of **c**.

The editors of that edition (also the *ECM*) identified about 310 continuous-text MSS containing all or part of Revelation, plus a few that have a more recent Greek, no longer the Koine; these were not considered. There are 14 fragments that are so small that they were not analyzed (5 papyri, 6 uncials, 3 cursives). There are 13 MSS that are isolated, not part of any group or family (P^{47} P^{115} ℵ, A, C and 8 cursives); if they are not part of any line of transmission, they are fabricated copies, not faithful copies of their exemplar; or they were not copied to produce their own line of transmission (in that event, why were they not copied?). There are 12 cursives considered to be 'mixed' (I classified a few others differently); if they are mixed, they are subsequent to the lines that they mixed. If we subtract those 39 MSS from 310, we are left with 271. There are at least 8 that are not available, plus another 11 that the editors felt to have been influenced by a published edition, in one way or another. Subtracting those 19 from 271 we are left with 252.

For 'Andreas', the editors identified 22 MSS that were not collated by Hoskier (one of them being a fragment). Since they did not divide them between **d** and **e**, I am obliged to just call them 'Andreas', but those 22 are presumably divided. Family **d** now has 11 representatives, apart from GA 2034 that appears to be a copy of GA 2036. Family **e** now has 29 representatives, apart from GA 2886 that appears to be a copy of GA 2920 (Hoskier's 205 and 209 are together now called 2920), and GA 2029 that appears to be a copy of GA 2028. GA 2926$^{[1;1\text{-}3:12]}$ is **e**, but the rest is **c**, so I did not count it here. Adding 22 +11 + 29 gives us 62 representatives for 'Andreas'.

For 'Koine', the editors identified 20 MSS that were not collated by Hoskier. Since they did not assign them to any of Hoskier's subdivisions, I am obliged to just call them 'Koine', but those 20 are presumably divided. Family **a** now has 16 representatives. Subdivision **a-b** now has 15 representatives, apart from GA 2258 that appears to be a copy of GA 2076, but including the 'twins' GA 2070 and 2305 for 12:1-22:21, the first half being **f**. The subdivision **a-c** now has 6

representatives. The subdivision **a-d** still has 16 representatives. The subdivision **a-e** now has 3 representatives. The subdivision **a-g** still has 6 representatives. Family **i**, that is included in 'Koine', now has 5 representatives. Adding 20 + 16 + 15 + 6 + 16 + 3 + 6 + 5 gives us 87 representatives for 'Koine'. However, family **b** almost always goes with **a**, so adding its 10 representatives gives us 97. Further, although families **f** and **g** independently go with family **c**, from time to time, they are both basically 'Koine'. **f** and **g** are represented by 14 and 10 MSS, respectively, so adding them we get 121 representatives for 'Koine'.

To give a clearer picture, **b**, **f** and **g** independently go with family **c** as follows: **b** 18 times, **f** 12 times, **g** 34 times, **b&f** 3 times, **b&g** 20 times and **f&g** 2 times. There is so much fuzz that the calculation is not simple, but it is clear that the three groups are part of 'Koine'.

As for 'Complutensian', family **c**, the editors assigned 36 representative MSS to it, including one fragment. Based on my own collations, I make the number to be 42, including the same fragment, plus 4 marginal members. As I mentioned above, the editors divided my family **h** into three small groups, represented by 5, 7 and 7 MSS, respectively. They oscillate between 'Andreas' and 'Koine'. So then, 'Koine' has about as many representatives as 'Andreas' and 'Complutensian' combined, and 'Complutensian' has the fewest. However, witnesses should be weighed and not just counted. I will now attempt some objective weighing.

What the *TuT* editors call 'Koine' includes seven divisions, according to Hoskier. The editors also recognized families **b**, **f** and **g**, which make ten divisions, if they are included. 'Koine' does not have a single archetypal form. 'Andreas' includes families **d** and **e; d** is solid, but **e** has many different internal divisions. 'Andreas' does not have a single archetypal form. I will handle 'Complutensian', family **c**, separately.

I checked all 45 representative MSS (according to my calculation, minus the fragment) of family **c**, my Family 35, at the 29 places where there is a division of 15% or more within the family. Of those 29, 16 are simply alternate spellings of the same word (usually involving a single letter); they are not proper variants, since they make no difference at all. Of the 13 cases that remain: 3 involve a single letter that makes little difference in the meaning; 2 change the gender of the same form, making little difference in the meaning; 2 change the case of the same form, making little difference in the meaning; 1 involves synonyms that give the same translation; 5 change the form of the same verb, making little difference in the meaning. Conclusion: the family is solid, without a single division that really changes the meaning. 'Complutensian' <u>does</u> have a single archetypal form, that I have published.

Now then, since the Original wording of Revelation is the ultimate Archetype, any candidate for true representative of that Archetype should also be an archetype. Of the three main lines of transmission, only one has an objectively defined archetype, so it is the best candidate of the three. Please notice that my weighing used only objective evidence, not subjective preference. But there is still more evidence to be considered.

I will use **a** to represent 'Koine', **d** to represent 'Andreas' and **c** to represent 'Complutensian'. There is a great deal of fuzz, or mixture, because bits and pieces of **a** and **d** are erratic, very erratic. **c** is solid. I tried to follow ¾ or more of each 'family', so the numbers I give are approximate, but the 'big picture' remains valid.

There are about 153 places, throughout the book of Revelation, where **a&c** join against **d**, about 174 different places where **c&d** join against **a**, but only 16 places where **a&d** join against **c** (+ 11 others where one of the two is split). So **c** is the common denominator, and therefore presumably older and better than the other two. The picture is reminiscent of that in the *Pericope*. Further, there are comparatively few places where **a&c**, **c&d** and **a&d** are 'clean', without any fuzz or mixture, because of the 'erraticity' within **a** and **d** (not **c**). The erratic nature of **a** and **d** does not help their credibility.

I will now analyze the places where **a&d** join against **c.** Of the 16 clear cases, 11 make no difference in the meaning; 3 make a little difference; and 2 do make some difference: one changes the gender, changing the reference from the four living beings to the twelve elders, and the other changes the case from nominative to genitive, which is clearly a grammatical mistake. As for the 11 places where one of the two is split, 4 make no difference in the meaning; 5 make a little difference; and 2 do make some difference: one changes an adverb to a relative pronoun (one letter) and the other omits the final clause from "who is, who was and who is coming", leaving just "who is, who was", which is clearly a mistake. So we are left with two cases that can be said to make some difference, for the whole book of Revelation. That is not enough to challenge the category of family **c** (Family 35) as the common denominator.

Another thing: throughout the whole book of Revelation, Family 35 is entirely alone only four times; otherwise at least a smattering of different MSS share its reading. There are a further four times that only CP joins F35, but I do not know which MSS the Cardinal used. That picture goes along with my thesis that F35 is the core of the transmission from which all other lines departed, at different times and places.

Partisans of an eclectic model have often claimed that the Byzantine bulk of the NT MSS is the result of control; that the Byzantine text is a controlled text. And

yet, that text is not monolithic; there are many divisions within it, as in Revelation. In stark contrast to all other lines of transmission, Family 35 is indeed monolithic. I hold nearly identical copies of F35 MSS from five different centuries and from isolated monasteries scattered all around the Mediterranean world. At no time during the history of the Church was there ever a human agency that could impose the level of control necessary to produce that result. The Holy Spirit is the only Agent who could have done it, and since the result exists, He must indeed have done it. (Is scientific knowledge not based on the principle of cause and effect? We observe an effect and try to identify the cause.) But why would the Holy Spirit want to control any line of transmission? And in the event, why would He choose only one? If He inspired the NT Text, He would want to preserve it. And it would be precisely the original wording that He would want to preserve. And He would have to choose a line of transmission to do the preserving down through the centuries. All the evidence that I have seen indicates that He chose Family 35.